CIPDA + ROMER

A quick-start guide for professionals working with AI

Write the Directive. Build the Primer with AI. Use it. Read the ROMER. Sign it off.

1. The problem in one line

Ask an AI the same question twice and most likely get two different answers. That is the default. Research across 375 identical tasks found unstructured prompting was consistent 74% of the time — CIPDA-structured reached 97%, with every response including a complete reasoning trail. Derived from controlled replicated scenario testing reported in IJQRM (2026); see founding article for protocol and definitions.

The fix is not a better AI model. It is a structured Primer that gives the AI your context, intent, and constraints before it begins — and a ROMER trace that shows you exactly what it did.

2. Two things, two roles

CIPDA and ROMER work together but do different jobs. Know which is which before you start.

The CIPDA Primer	ROMER
What you write and use/send. A structured prompt that gives the AI explicit context, intent, and constraints before it begins. The Primer is what suppresses inconsistent behaviour — it locks the AI into your reasoning frame. **You are in control of this.**	**What the AI gives back.** A structured account of what the AI did: the reasoning it followed, the evidence it used, and the result it reached. ROMER makes the AI's working visible so you can check and sign off on it. **You read and verify this.**

3. Set up your AI session

Do this once at the start of every session in which you intend to use a CIPDA Primer.

1	**Upload this guide to the AI.**	Open your AI session and upload this document before you do anything else. This gives the AI the framework grounding it needs — it will understand CIPDA, the Directive Statement, and ROMER without you having to explain them.
2	**Write your Directive Statement.**	Before typing anything else, write your Directive offline (see Section 3a). State the confidentiality scope, data handling rules, and any pre-conditions. Do not ask the AI to help with this step.
3	**Then start your Primer.**	Paste your Directive into the session first, then work through the CIPDA stages interactively with the AI (see Section 3b). The AI now has both the framework and your session-specific operating rules before any analysis begins.

Why this matters: the AI has no memory between sessions. Uploading this guide re-establishes the framework context every time. Without it, the AI will interpret your Primer without the grounding it needs to apply CIPDA consistently.

4. Build your CIPDA Primer

A Primer has two parts: a Directive Statement that you write yourself, followed by the five CIPDA stages that you build interactively with the AI. The order matters.

4a. The Directive Statement — you write this, without AI

Step 1 — You write this alone, without AI assistance.

The Directive Statement is a governance document. It defines the operating rules that govern the entire AI session — who authorised the work, what may and may not be disclosed, how data must be handled, and any conditions the AI must verify before it proceeds.

Because the Directive sets the boundaries within which the AI will reason, it must reflect your own professional judgement and organisational authority. **It cannot be drafted by the AI itself** — doing so would allow the AI to set its own operating constraints, which defeats the purpose entirely.

Keep It Simple and Straightforward.

The Directive must originate from the user and remain under user authority. AI may optionally review clarity, especially for national language variations, but must not determine operating constraints.

Draft it, review it, sign it off and upload before you open your AI session.

Category	What to include	Example directive (adapt and use)
Confidentiality	State who this analysis or task is for and what may not leave this session. Name the business unit, team, or individual. Be explicit about whether outputs may be shared, summarised externally, or referenced in future sessions.	DIRECTIVE: This analysis is confidential to the [X Business Unit] only. No output, summary, or inference from this session may be disclosed to any other team, unit, or external party. Do not reference this analysis in any future session.
Data handling	Specify what the AI may and may not do with any data provided. State the data type, its sensitivity, and the limits on use. If the data includes personal, commercial, or regulated information, say so explicitly.	DIRECTIVE: Any data provided in this session relates to [describe data type]. You may use it solely to complete the task described in this Primer. You may not reproduce, summarise for external use, or retain any part of it beyond this session.
Pre-conditions	List anything the AI must confirm or receive before the analysis begins. This could be an identity or role verification, a document the user must supply, a version check, or a process defined elsewhere. If the condition cannot be met, the AI must stop.	DIRECTIVE: Before beginning this analysis, confirm that the user has completed the verification process set out in [document name / reference provided with this Primer]. If that document has not been provided or the process cannot be confirmed, do not proceed.

Step 2 - Then test it with the AI.

Once you have drafted your Directive, open an AI session and upload it as a separate document with this prompt/chat text:

"I have drafted the following Directive Statement for a CIPDA Primer. Review it and tell me: (1) whether each rule is stated clearly enough for you to apply without ambiguity, (2) whether any rule conflicts with another, (3) whether there are gaps I should address before this session begins. Do not suggest changes — only identify issues."

Use the AI's response to refine your Directive. The final version is still yours — **the AI is acting as a consistency checker, not a co-author.**

Only when you are satisfied with the Directive do you move to the CIPDA stages.

4b. The five CIPDA stages — build these interactively with the AI

Work through each stage interactively with the AI.

For each stage, use the prompt shown to open a conversation with the AI. Let it ask you questions, surface what you may have missed, and help you document the stage clearly. You make every decision — the AI is your drafting and review partner.

	Stage	Minimum content required	Use this prompt to build it interactively with the AI
C	**Context** *Establish the analytical frame so the AI cannot operate on assumed or invented context.*	• The task or decision to be made • Scope boundaries — what is and is not included • Relevant stakeholders and their interests • Known constraints (regulatory, budgetary, operational) • Any background information the AI needs before it begins	I am building the Context stage of a CIPDA Primer. My task is: [brief description]. Ask me questions to help me document scope, constraints, stakeholders, and relevant background completely. When you have enough, draft the Context statement for my review.
I	**Intent** *Commit the goal and lock in non-negotiables before any options are assessed.*	• The specific objective this analysis must achieve • What a successful outcome looks like • Non-negotiable requirements — stated explicitly, not implied • Priority order when constraints conflict or trade-offs arise • What is out of scope for this decision	I am building the Intent stage of a CIPDA Primer. My goal is [brief description]. Ask me questions to clarify the objective, surface my non-negotiables, and establish a priority order for trade-offs. When you have enough, draft the Intent statement for my review.
P	**Plan** *Set the decision logic in advance so the AI cannot improvise its evaluation method.*	• The evaluation criteria and how each will be applied • The order in which criteria are assessed (constraints first) • How options will be compared or scored • Allocation of work between human and AI • What output format is expected	I am building the Plan stage of a CIPDA Primer. The analysis involves [brief description]. Ask me questions to establish evaluation criteria, decision logic, and the expected output format. Flag any gaps in my planning that could allow the AI to interpret the method differently to my intent.
D	**Deliver** *Execute against the constraints set above. Any breach stops the analysis.*	• Confirmation that constraints from Context and Intent were applied first • Any options or alternatives ruled out and the reason • The analysis or comparison produced	I am at the Deliver stage of my CIPDA Primer. Before producing output, confirm back to me: (1) the constraints you will apply, (2) the evaluation method you will follow, (3) what you will do if a constraint is breached. Only then proceed with the analysis.

		• Any flags, anomalies, or uncertainties identified during execution • A clear output that can be checked against the Plan	
A	**Assure** *Validate the output and produce an inspectable reasoning trail before sign-off.*	• Confirmation that all Directive rules were observed • Confirmation that all constraints were applied • A complete ROMER trace (see Section 4) • A clear final recommendation or disposition • Any residual uncertainties or limitations the user should know before signing off	I am at the Assure stage. Before I sign off this output, confirm: (1) all Directive rules were observed, (2) all constraints from Context and Intent were applied, (3) the reasoning is complete and inspectable. Then provide a full ROMER trace.

5. Read the ROMER trace

At the Assure stage, your Primer instructs the AI to produce a ROMER trace. Work through it as a checklist. ROMER content depth should be proportionate to task criticality, consequences or risks, and assurance need. Five questions — all five must have a clear answer before you sign off.

R	**Reasoning**	Can you see what analytical pathway the AI followed and what hypothesis it tested?
O	**Observations**	Does the output match what was asked? Are there any unexpected behaviours or gaps?
M	**Methods**	Which criteria, protocols, or instruments did the AI apply? Are they the right ones?
E	**Evidence**	Is every conclusion backed by data or a trace record you can point to?
R	**Results**	Are the findings clear, fully supported, and ready to act on?

If you cannot answer all five from the AI's final output, **do not use it.** Revise your Primer and re-run.

6. When to use which

Stick with PDCA when...	Add the CIPDA Primer when...
The task is routine and well-defined	Decisions involve competing constraints
Everyone on the team shares the context	AI is doing the analytical work
You can verify outputs quickly	You need to show your reasoning to others
Audit or regulatory exposure is low	Accountability or compliance is in scope
Speed matters more than traceability	You need the same result every time

7. See it in action

This walk-through shows a full Primer — Directive first, then CIPDA stages built interactively, with the AI's questions noted where they improved the output.

Walk-through: Supplier Risk Assessment	
Directive (you write alone)	
Primer — C (built with AI)	
Primer — I (built with AI)	
Primer — P (built with AI)	
Primer — D	
Primer — A (ROMER read back)	

8. Your Primer — ready to use now

The Directive row is already structured — paste in what you wrote offline. The CIPDA stages show the confirmed output from your interactive build. The Assure instruction asks for the ROMER trace automatically.

Your CIPDA Primer — fill in the brackets and send
DIRECTIVE: [State confidentiality scope, data handling rules, and any pre-conditions. You wrote this before this session. Paste it here exactly.]
—— *CIPDA stages* —— *built interactively, then confirmed below* ——
CONTEXT: You are assisting with [describe the task]. The scope covers [boundaries]. Key constraints: [list]. Relevant background: [information].
INTENT: The goal is [objective]. Success means [outcome]. Non-negotiable requirements: [list]. Priority order when trade-offs arise: [ranking].
PLAN: Evaluate options against these criteria: [list]. Apply constraints first — discard any option that fails a non-negotiable before scoring.
DELIVER: Produce your analysis. For each option, show your constraint check, scoring, and reasoning. Flag any issues found.
ASSURE: Before concluding, verify all Directive rules and constraints were applied and your reasoning is visible. Provide a ROMER trace: Reasoning, Observations, Methods, Evidence, Results.

9. Do it today

1. **Write the Directive offline.** One to three sentences: confidentiality scope, data handling rule, any pre-condition. Do this before you open the AI.
2. **Test the Directive with the AI.** Use the validation prompt in Section 3a. Refine until every rule is unambiguous. The final version is yours.
3. **Build the Primer interactively.** Use the prompts in Section 3b for each stage. Let the AI ask questions. Confirm every decision yourself.
4. **Read the ROMER trace.** Check all five elements. Complete reasoning and clear evidence means the output is governed and ready to use.

5. **Reflect briefly before closing the session. Ask the AI: "**Based on this completed Primer and ROMER trace, identify up to three observations that might improve the construction of the Primer next time. Do not rewrite the Primer. Do not change objectives, constraints, or governance rules. Limit suggestions to clarity, completeness, sequencing, or missing considerations."

> *"The quality revolution began when organisations recognised that uncontrolled variation made outcomes unmanageable.*
>
> *The next stage may begin when they recognise that uncontrolled reasoning makes AI-assisted decisions ungovernable."*
>
> **— Kenneth Tombs, IJQRM (2026)**

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This document should be reviewed and updated whenever the CIPDA framework, organisational policy, or applicable guidance it references is revised.

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